

image. If these renowned institutions are kept away from politics and from being politicised, they will grow to become global destinations in the near future.

K. CHIDANAND KUMAR,
Bangalore

Fair Practice

In this man's world, woman's subjugation, exploitation and humiliation is a universal phenomenon ("Married to Controversy", September 1). As a mark of honour to the fairer sex, Naish, a Lucknow-based social activist, getting her marriage solemnised by a woman cleric Syeda Hameed, is indeed a welcome change, and should not be seen as an attempt to break away from the Islamic tradition. If accepted and awarded religious sanction, it will herald a new chapter in Islam, which appoints women as preachers (in Morocco), but stops short of allowing them to lead the prayers.

VIRENDRA KUMAR TANGRI,
on e-mail

Maya's Magic

Mayawati means roller of wealth, and also the creator and dispenser of illusions ("Can She Rule India", August 18). The chief minister of Uttar Pradesh is gifted with these twin attributes which will surely pave her way to becoming an important player in national politics, and fulfilling her long-cherished dream of becoming the prime minister of the country. However, the ball now lies in the voters' court who have to decide and accept her as someone who can be trusted with

the responsibility of governing India in the near future.

SHANTI PRAKASH KARIR,
on e-mail

War for Title

It is ironical that even 61 years after Independence, much after the abolition of zamindari, princely states and privy purses, two gentlemen are fighting for a title that hardly means anything today ("Fake Nawabs", August 18). It is like the mock-epic battle

between the ladies and gentlemen for the possession of Belinda's ravished lock of hair in Alexander Pope's *The Rape of the Lock* which disappeared during the course of the battle. It appears that the nawabs are suffering from an identity crisis and are victims of delusions of grandeur. Isn't it surprising that such vestiges of colonialism like the British India Association still exist in a free India?

PROFESSOR SYED ALI HAMID,
Almora

GAMING SPIRIT



It is the winning spirit and positive attitude towards games, coupled with hard work, proper guidance and training which alone can motivate and inspire our sportspersons to win awards and bring laurels.

MAHESH KAPASI, on e-mail

After winning three medals for the first time in Olympics, let's not sit on our laurels. We still have a long way to go. The sportspersons need to be focussed in their pursuit while the government needs to come forward and provide infrastructure and resources to help them. Can we do this? If yes, then the sky is the limit for us at all such future sporting events.

COLONEL R.D. SINGH, Leh

The curtain has fallen on the Beijing Olympics and we have once again proved that participating is more important than winning. It's indeed sad that a nation of over a billion with a team of 56 sportspersons in Beijing could manage only three medals.

NAVNITH KRISHNAN, Bangalore

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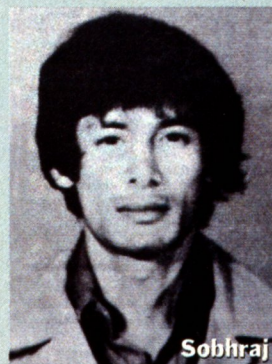
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Years Ago in India Today

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Sobhraj

End of the Trail

At regular intervals during the past two months, a frail, manacled prisoner strapped to a stretcher and accompanied by a formidable, heavily-armed police escort has been driven out of Tihar Jail en route to the courts. Apart from a few curious onlookers lounging around the courtrooms, the grim-looking procession goes virtually unnoticed. Yet, barely a year ago, the mild-looking prisoner was the most wanted man in Asia, accused of a string of daredevil crimes ranging from forgery to robbery and poisoning to murder. His name—Charles Hotchand Bhawani Sobhraj, described as "one of the most accomplished murderers in the annals of modern crime". Sobhraj's sensational arrest by the Delhi Police last year, climaxed a career that reads straight out of a James Hadley Chase thriller. Police spokesmen claim they have enough cases against Sobhraj to keep him behind bars for the rest of his life.

—Dilip Bobb
with Asoka Raina